GDG Algiers ER: Convincing a Reluctant Sponsor

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I would listen first, answer each objection with evidence and measurable goals, offer a small low-risk trial if they still hesitate, and stop after two respectful attempts.

1. Arguments

I start by asking what they sponsored before, what result they expected and what they got. Their bad experience is valid, and knowing it lets me answer the real objection instead of repeating a pitch.

Their objection	My answer
"Sponsoring student events is pointless."	These students are tomorrow's developers, hires and early adopters. DevFest has run for 11 editions with 2K+ attendees and 700+ hackathon participants listed on the event page.
"We tried it and got nothing out of it."	Many past sponsorships are a logo with no goal. I would agree on 2 or 3 measurable results first (for example CVs collected, hackathon submissions using their product, sign-ups) and send a report with the numbers after the event.
"Facebook ads and posters are better."	Ads buy impressions from people who are scrolling. At DevFest the company gets time with an engaged tech audience: a talk, a hackathon challenge and direct conversations. GDG Algiers' channels (Facebook 20k+, Instagram 20k+, LinkedIn 11k+, Discord 4k+) add reach on top of their ads, not instead of them.
"We prefer to keep the budget for advertising."	I am not asking to move the whole budget, only a small share, with a clear return.

Their objection	My answer
"Students are not our customers."	For a tech company they are a hiring pipeline. In 2021, InstaDeep offered the hackathon winners internship interviews and AI training, a real example of recruitment value.

I would tailor the pitch to what that company wants most (hiring, brand or product adoption) and keep it to a few lines: "You told me past sponsorships gave you no results. Let us agree on the results you want first, test it on a small scale, and judge us on the numbers."

2. A small entry point

If they still say no, I propose a trial they can try with limited risk. I only promise what the team can deliver.

Entry point	What they give	What they get	Risk for them
Named challenge or prize	One hackathon challenge or prize, in-kind or small cash	Their problem solved by student teams, a mention at the opening, access to the best solutions	Low
Talk and internship board	One engineer's time and a few internship offers	A speaking slot and an opt-in list of interested candidates	Very low
Bronze package	200,000 DA from the offer sheet	Logo on posters and flyers, low social visibility	Medium
Pilot with agreed results	Any of the above	A short report with the agreed numbers, and first option to upgrade next edition at the same terms	Low

I would start with the first two, since they ask for the least money and let the company see the audience in person.

3. When to stop insisting

I stop when any of these happens:

- they have refused twice, once to the full pitch and once to the small entry point;
- they give a reason that will not change, such as a frozen budget or a policy against sponsoring events;
- keeping the deal alive would require promises we cannot deliver, exclusivity or a price below our minimum acceptable agreement;
- my follow-ups start to feel like pressure instead of conversation.

I stop because repeated pushing looks desperate, wastes time that is better spent on the next prospect, and can harm the relationship and GDG Algiers' reputation. The ER guidelines say the aim is a partnership that makes sense for both sides, not the largest possible contribution.

I would stop politely: thank them, ask permission to send the post-event report, propose to talk again before the next edition, ask whether someone else in the company should know about us, and log the reason in the contact tracker.